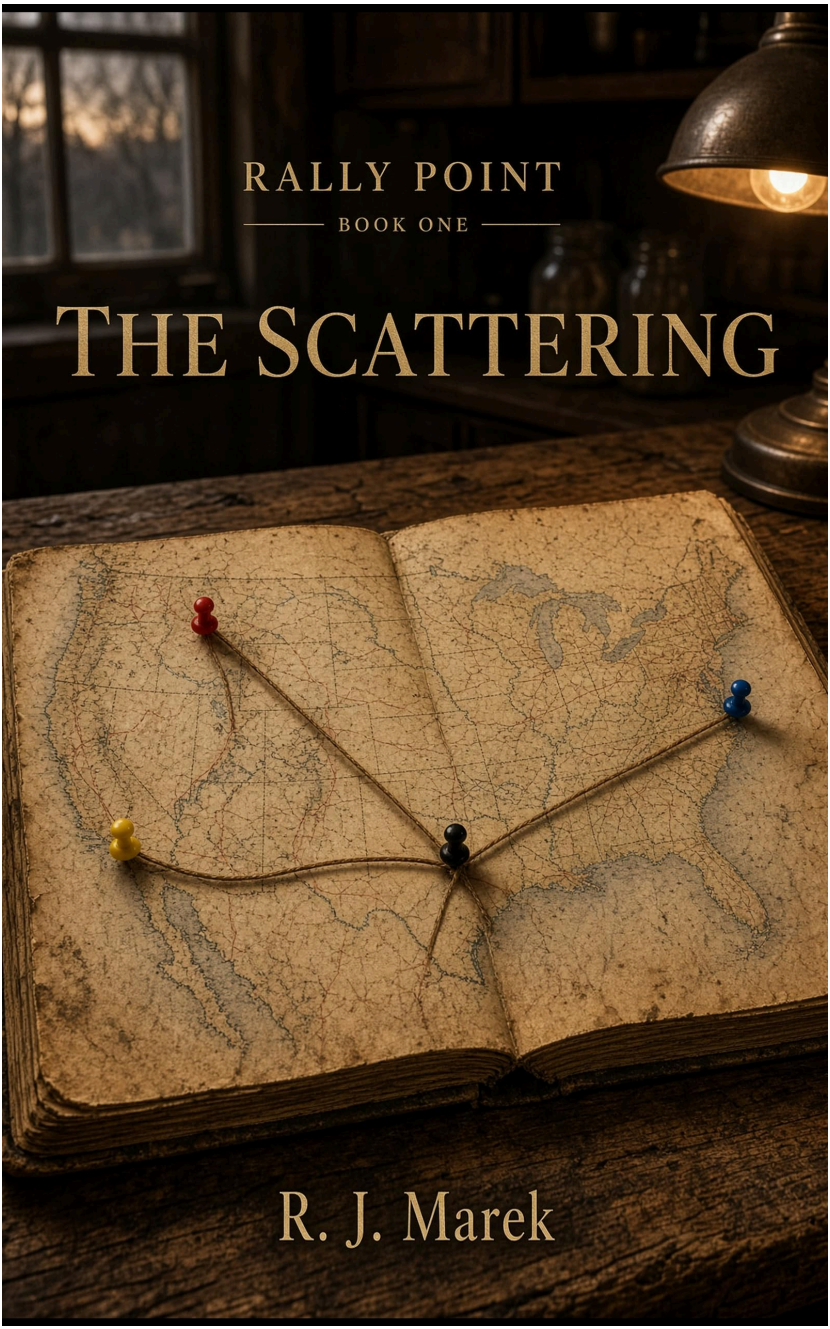

RALLY POINT
BOOK ONE
THE SCATTERING
R. J. Marek

The Scattering

Rally Point, Book One

R. J. Marek

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Chapter One: The People Who Prepared

Eckert Ranch, Gillespie County, Texas, Twenty-five days before

Ray Eckert had buried three hundred pounds of rice in his back forty, and his children thought this was the single funniest thing a human being had ever done.

They didn’t say so anymore, not to his face — they were grown now, scattered to three time zones and two continents, too old to roll their eyes where he could see them. But he knew. He could hear it in the pause before Ben said *that’s really smart, Dad* in the same voice the boy used to tell his grandmother he loved the sweater. He could hear it in the way Rachel called the root cellar “the bunker” with the little quotation marks built right into the word. He’d raised three smart-mouthed kids and every one of them had grown up to be exactly smart-mouthed enough to survive him.

He didn’t mind. A man who prepared for the worst got to spend his whole life being wrong in the most pleasant possible way, right up until the one day he wasn’t. Ray had made his peace with being the punchline. It was a small price for the arithmetic that let him sleep: two people, one ranch, water in the ground and food in the earth and a way to keep both if the trucks ever stopped coming.

The trucks always came. That was the thing his kids couldn’t feel in their bones the way he did. They’d never watched a supply line die. He had, once, a long time ago, in a country he didn’t talk about, and it had rearranged something permanent in him. You could put the shelves back. You couldn’t put back the part of a man that had seen how fast the shelves emptied.

It was a Sunday at the worn end of a hot Texas summer, and Ray was on his knees in the garden pretending to check the drip lines so June wouldn't catch him resting. Sixty-one years old and his knees announced it to him twice a day like a court crier. The okra was coming in. The stock tank was three-quarters full. Somewhere out past the cedar break a pair of his neighbor's longhorns were complaining about nothing, the way cattle did, and the whole ranch smelled like hot rock and mesquite and the particular green sweetness of things that were, for the moment, alive and growing and completely fine.

"Raymond." June's voice came down the hill from the porch. "It's seven. They're calling in."

"Comin'."

"You said that ten minutes ago."

"And I meant it both times."

He got up in stages, the way he did everything now, and stood a second looking at his land the way he'd never once told anyone he did — that quick private inventory, gate to tank to house to the far line of hills going blue with evening. Then he went up to the porch where his wife was sitting with the laptop propped on the little folding table, her reading glasses down her nose, frowning at the spinning circle that meant the internet was thinking about whether it felt like working.

June Eckert had spent thirty years in the emergency room of a Level I trauma center in San Antonio, and it had given her two things that never left: a spine of rebar, and a sense of humor that most people found alarming until they understood it was the only reason she was still standing.

“There he is,” she said, as the screen unfroze into a grid of her children’s faces. “The famous rice farmer.”

“Hi, Dad.” Ben, top left, in his dorm room in San Diego, backlit by a window so bright he was mostly a silhouette with hair. Twenty years old and still, to his mother, roughly the size and weight he’d been the day they handed him to her.

“Turn a light on, I can’t see you,” June said.

“You can see me fine.”

“I can see the *outline* of you. For all I know you’ve been replaced.”

“That would explain the improved grades,” said Rachel, bottom right, and Ben said something back that the software chopped into digital confetti, and for a second all three of them were talking over each other, and Ray settled into the porch chair next to his wife with the specific animal contentment of a man whose whole family was, however briefly, in one rectangle.

Rachel was in her kitchen in Montana, still in the fleece she wore to work, which meant she’d either just gotten back from a call or was about to leave for one; with Rachel there was very little daylight between the two. Behind her the window showed the Bitterroots doing the thing they did in the evening, going purple and enormous. Daniel wasn’t up yet. He would be — it was two in the morning where he was, and he’d promised, and Daniel kept his promises with the grim reliability the United States Navy had beaten into him.

“Dan’s going to be late,” Rachel said. “He texted. Duty section got shuffled.”

“He texted *you*,” June said.

“I’m the favorite. We’ve discussed this.”

“You’re the oldest. It’s not the same thing.”

“It is when the other options are a Navy enlisted man and whatever Ben is currently majoring in.”

“Mechanical engineering,” Ben said, wounded. “Same as Dad.”

“Dad can fix a well pump. Can you fix a well pump?”

“I can Google how to fix a well pump.”

“For about a week,” Ray said mildly, “and then you can’t, because there’s no Google,” and there it was — the small silence his family always left around the things he said, the beat where they decided whether to take the bait. This time Rachel took it, gently, the way you’d take a plate from an old man’s hands.

“Okay, Ray. What’s the disaster this week. Give it to us.”

He hadn’t been going to say anything. That was the truth he’d tell June later, in bed, when it mattered. He hadn’t been going to bring it up because it was still four paragraphs down the page, still *somewhere else’s problem*, still the kind of thing that made his kids exchange the look. But his daughter had asked, in that indulgent voice, and some old instinct made him answer her straight.

“There’s a bird flu in Asia,” he said. “H5N1. Been around for years — you’d remember it if you followed the poultry markets, which none of you do, God love you. Kills damn near everybody it infects. Only good news about it was it never learned to jump person to person. Just bird to person, now and then, and that was bad enough.” He paused. “There’s a cluster now that looks like it might’ve learned.”

“Might’ve,” Rachel said.

“Might’ve.”

“So it’s nothing,” said Ben.

“Probably it’s nothing.” Ray meant it, or ninety percent meant it. “These things fizzle nine times out of ten. The reporting’s thin. Could be a bad translation, could be a lab getting ahead of itself.” He shrugged. “I bought some more chicken feed and I topped off the diesel. That’s the whole of my response. You can all go back to making fun of the rice.”

“We would never,” said Rachel.

“We make fun of the rice out of love,” said Ben.

“The rice,” June said, “is going to outlive all of us, and on that day I want it read into the record that I said so.” But Ray had felt her go still beside him — just slightly, just the smallest tightening, the way she used to go still in the ER when the radio crackled and the number of incoming didn’t match the number of beds. He glanced at her. She was smiling at the screen. She was not, underneath the smile, anywhere near as relaxed as her children needed her to be, and she was hiding it from them with the ease of thirty years’ practice, and that — more than anything her husband had said — was the thing that should have scared them all.

It didn’t. Because she was good at her job, and because they were her kids, and because it was a warm Sunday evening and the okra was coming in and the trucks, as always, were still running.

Daniel logged on at the forty-minute mark, hair wet, in a gray Navy T-shirt, apologizing, five thousand miles away and yawning, and for another half hour the Eckerts were simply a family on a phone call, arguing about nothing, and no one wrote down the date, because no one knew yet that it was the last ordinary one they’d get.

Later, June would remember it to the hour.

Chapter Two: Large Animal

Stevensville, Bitterroot Valley, Montana, Three weeks before

The call came at 2:40 in the morning, which was how Rachel Eckert knew it was real. Nobody rang a vet at 2:40 for anything that could wait for coffee.

“Doc.” Owen Petrie, out on the county line, his voice doing the thing men’s voices did when they were scared and pretending not to be. “It’s Duchess. She’s been at it three hours and there’s a foot showing and it ain’t moving and I can’t—” A pause full of barn sounds. “I can’t get in there right, my hands are too big, Carol’s back is out. I need you.”

“Front foot or back?”

“How the hell do I—”

“Is the bottom of the hoof pointing up or down, Owen.”

A long silence. Rachel was already dressed. That was the thing people never understood about the job — that the animal in her hands could change but the choreography never did, that she could be pulling her boots on in the dark and diagnosing a malpresentation over the phone at the same time and feel, underneath the adrenaline, something that was almost peace. Out here, in the work, she knew exactly what she was for.

“Down,” Owen said. “Pointing down.”

“That’s a front foot and that’s good. Means she’s coming the right way, just stuck. Don’t pull on anything. I’m twenty minutes out.”

She made it in sixteen.

The Petrie barn was warm with the smell of blood and straw and the big laboring animal in the corner stall, and Rachel stripped to a T-shirt in the mountain cold and soaped her arm to the shoulder and went in after the calf with the particular calm that had made her, at thirty-four, the vet three valleys trusted more than they trusted their own doctors. Duchess bawled and shuddered. Rachel found the second foot tucked back where it shouldn't be, hooked it forward with two fingers and a prayer, and talked the whole time in the low running monologue that was half for the cow and half for Owen, who was standing at the stall rail with his hat in his hands like a man at a graveside.

"There's the other foot, big girl, that's all it was, you just had him folded up wrong like a lawn chair — okay, Owen, now we pull, *with* her, when she pushes, not before — there — *there*—"

The calf came out in a rush of fluid and steam and lay in the straw not breathing, and Rachel cleared its mouth and rubbed it hard with a fistful of dry hay and stuck a piece of straw up its nose to make it cough, and the calf sneezed and shook its wet head and took its first outraged breath of the world, and Owen Petrie made a sound that he would deny to his dying day and turned away to wipe his face on his sleeve.

"Bull calf," Rachel said. "Big one. That's your problem right there." She sat back on her heels in the straw, arm ruined to the shoulder, blood to the elbow, grinning like an idiot in the way she only ever did at three in the morning in someone's barn. This. This was the part they didn't put on the brochure and it was the only part that had ever mattered. "He's fine. She's fine. You're the only casualty and that's just your dignity, which'll grow back."

“Doc, I could kiss you.”

“Please don’t. Coffee, though. If that’s on the table.”

It was, and afterward they stood in the barn doorway in the enormous Montana dark drinking it, watching the calf figure out its legs, and that was when Owen said the thing that stayed with her.

“You hear about the folks moving through Lolo?”

“What folks.”

“Coming over from Idaho. The panhandle.” He turned his mug in his hands. “Bud Reyes says a whole convoy came through the pass last week. Trucks, trailers. Flags.” He said the last word carefully. Everyone in the valley knew what kind of flags came out of that particular corner of Idaho; it was old history up here, the compounds and the men who’d run them, history that the valley had spent thirty years being quietly, tiredly proud of having pushed out. “Reyes said they weren’t stopping. Said they were buying, though. Buying everything. Fuel, ammunition, canned goods. Paying cash, real polite, cleaned out the Conner store in twenty minutes and left.”

“Buying for what?”

Owen shrugged, but it wasn’t a real shrug. “Man buys three years of ammunition, he’s got a plan for it. That’s all I’m saying.” He looked out at the mountains. “Probably nothing.”

“Probably nothing,” Rachel agreed, and heard, distinctly, her father’s voice in her own mouth, and hated how much it sounded like sense.

She drove home as the sky went gray behind the Sapphires, past the dark shapes of ranches she’d worked her whole career, the Hendersons’, the old Wallace place, the little rescue outfit where the

woman kept the three-legged donkey that Rachel treated for free and would deny doing so. She loved this valley with an intensity that had frightened her husband, once, before the fire, back when there'd been a husband to frighten. She'd stayed here for it after he died when everyone assumed she'd leave. She had built an entire self out of being the person this valley called at 2:40 in the morning.

At a stoplight in town — the one stoplight — she checked her phone. A text from her mother, sent at some Texas hour: *Wash your hands like it's your religion. Love you. Not kidding about the hands.*

Rachel frowned at it. Her mother didn't send things like that. Her mother sent recipes and pictures of the garden and the occasional devastating one-line observation about one of Rachel's life choices. *Wash your hands* was an ER nurse's instinct, and an ER nurse's instinct fired at a distance meant June Eckert had read something she didn't like.

The light turned green. Nobody was behind her; nobody was ever behind her at this hour. Rachel sat through the whole green anyway, thinking about flags coming over the pass and her mother's careful casual voice, and then she drove home and washed her hands like it was her religion and told herself, all the way down the drain, that it was probably nothing.

Chapter Three: Ship’s Company

Naval Station Rota, Andalusia, Spain, Seventeen days before

Gas Turbine Systems Technician First Class Daniel Eckert was four decks down in the hull with his arm inside a machine that could kill him in four separate ways, and he was, for the first time in a week, completely happy.

The number-two gas turbine generator on the destroyer *USS Bulkeley* had been throwing a fault code that three other people had failed to find, and Dan had been chasing it for two days, and he had it now — a corroded connector back behind a bracket that some sadist at the shipyard had installed with no human hand in mind. He had the connector. He had it by two fingers. If he could get a quarter-turn on it before his forearm cramped, he’d win, and winning against a machine was the purest feeling the Navy had ever given him, cleaner than any ribbon.

“Eckert.” Chief Ruiz’s boots appeared at the edge of the deck grating above him. “You alive down there.”

“Debatable, Chief.”

“You find it?”

“I’m touching it. If I stop touching it to talk to you it goes back to being lost, so respectfully—”

“Get it buttoned up and come see me when you’re topside. Not a drill. Just come see me.” The boots went away, and something in the flatness of the chief’s voice made Dan get the connector seated faster

than he should have, on feel, in the dark, the way you learned to do things in a Navy engine room where there was never enough light or room or time.

He'd joined at nineteen to get out of Texas and had stayed ten years because the Navy, for all its infinite capacity to make a simple thing stupid, had given him a thing he hadn't known he was starving for: a place where he was good at something that unambiguously mattered, surrounded by people who'd pull him out of a flooding space without being asked. His father thought the ranch was the safest place on earth. His father was wrong. The safest place on earth was a gray hull full of men and women who would die for you over a card debt, and Dan had never once regretted choosing it.

He'd have cause to remember thinking that.

Ruiz's office was a closet with delusions, and Ruiz filled most of it. He was a squat, unbothered man from El Paso who had been in the Navy since before Dan could drive, and who had exactly one facial expression, and it was the one he was wearing now, which was how Dan knew it was bad. Ruiz saved his other moods for when things were fine.

"Sit."

"I'll stand, Chief, I've been folded up like origami for two hours."

"Suit yourself." Ruiz turned his monitor a few degrees, not quite toward Dan, more like he was tired of looking at it himself. "You following the news at all? The flu thing?"

"Little bit. My old man's been on about it. He's on about everything, though, it's kind of his hobby."

"Your old man." Ruiz almost smiled. "The prepper."

“The very one.”

“Yeah, well.” The near-smile went away and didn’t come back. “Medical’s been getting traffic all week. Base is looking at movement restrictions. There’s cases in Rota — the town, I mean, off base. Couple in Cádiz. It’s in Madrid pretty bad, from what I hear, and Madrid’s not that far.” He rubbed his face. “We got a message this morning. Nothing’s decided. But they want departments thinking about a scenario where we’re at a higher readiness posture and liberty’s secured and — Eckert, they’re talking about the kind of thing where you don’t go home for a while.”

Dan felt it land somewhere below the sternum, a cold small weight. “Define a while.”

“I can’t, because nobody’s said. That’s the whole problem. Nobody’s saying anything, which is the loudest thing the Navy’s said to me in twenty-two years.” Ruiz looked up at him. “I’m telling my guys one at a time. If you got calls to make stateside, make ’em now, while the network’s good and the mood’s still light. Because if this is what it might be, the mood is not going to stay light.”

Dan thought about the ocean. He couldn’t help it; it was the first thing his mind went to and it went there whole. Between him and the ranch outside Fredericksburg there was a base, and a fence, and a chain of command, and then the Atlantic — three thousand miles of the single most indifferent thing on the planet. On a ship the ocean was a road. Standing on a pier watching your ship’s readiness posture go up, the ocean was a wall four thousand miles long, and Daniel Eckert understood, with the clarity he usually reserved for dangerous machinery, that he had spent his whole adult life on the wrong side of it from the people he loved and had never once thought of it that way until this exact moment in a closet in Spain.

“How bad do you think it is, Chief,” he said. “Off the record. Just you.”

Ruiz was quiet for a long moment. He was not, by nature, a man who dealt in fear; he dealt in work orders and duty rosters and the reliable machinery of a life spent keeping a ship alive.

“I think,” he said finally, “that in twenty-two years I have never gotten a message that told me to have my people call home while they still can. And I think you should go call your folks, Eckert. Tell ’em the rice was a good idea.” He turned back to his monitor. “And get that generator signed off before you do. World ends, I still don’t want a down gen on my report.”

Dan laughed, because it was funny, because Ruiz had made it funny on purpose, the way you’d hand a man a rail to hold on a rolling deck. Then he went up three ladders to where his phone would get a signal and stood at the rail in the Andalusian dark, looking west across the water toward a home he could not, in that moment, imagine any road back to, and he called the ranch.

His father answered on the second ring, wide awake though it was the middle of the night in Texas, because of course he was.

“Danny,” Ray said, and just the sound of it — the flat Hill Country calm of it, the complete absence of surprise, as if his father had been sitting up in the dark waiting for exactly this call for ten years — undid something in Dan’s chest that he’d been holding tight since Ruiz’s boots appeared over the grating.

“Hey, Dad,” he said. “So. About the rice.”

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